R1a1a detached themselves from their parent group and moved south to seek a new home for themselves as pastoralists in the grasslands east of the Caspian Sea. Here they tamed the horse and invented the light spoke-wheeled and horse-drawn chariot, as evidenced in the chariot burial sites of the Proto-Indo-Iranian-speaking Sintashta culture of the Northern Eurasian steppes.

Then in about 1900 BCE this horse-riding and cattle- and goatherding people (sometimes referred to as the Androvono culture) began to break up, possibly as a consequence of overgrazing or prolonged drought. Whatever the cause, these nomads split up, one large group moving westwards into Anatolia, another moving eastwards into what is now Western Mongolia to become the Wusun (‘descendants of the raven’), and a third group moving southwards into and through the region that the Greeks later named Bactria, essentially the river basin of today’s Amu Darya, formerly the Vedic Vaksu, the Greek Oxus. But then this third group again divided, one party moving westwards into what is now Iran, the other east into India. This move may also have been forced by overgrazing or drought, but a third possibility is that religious differences had grown that were too serious to be resolved, such as the emergence of proto-Zoroastrianism, with its worship of a sole creator, Ahura Mazda, ‘lord of wisdom’.

Whatever the reasons, from about 1500 BCE onwards a distinctly new form of society began to appear in the western Punjab, dominated by a vigorous and mobile people whose preferred mode of transport was the *asva*, or horse, and whose secret weapon was the fast-moving horse-drawn *ratha*, from *rotho*, or ‘wheel’.

During excavations carried out at Mohenjo-Daro in 1950 by the charismatic Sir Mortimer Wheeler, the last British archaeologist to head the ASI, a number of skeletons were uncovered which Wheeler declared to be victims of a massacre: Harappans killed by Arya invaders. Wheeler’s